



ALBERTA
PRIMARY AND PREVENTATIVE HEALTH SERVICES

*Office of the Minister
MLA, Red Deer-North*

AR 236347

November 17, 2025

Wayne Sorenson
President, Seniors United Now
37, 2016 Sherwood Drive
Sherwood Park AB T8A 3X3

Sent via email: unitenow@telus.net

Dear Wayne Sorenson:

Thank you for your letter on behalf of Seniors United Now (SUN) to the Honourable Danielle Smith, Premier of Alberta, and the Honourable Jason Nixon, Minister of Assisted Living and Social Services, regarding seniors' health care. As Minister of Primary and Preventative Health Services, I welcome the opportunity to respond on behalf of the Government of Alberta. I apologize for the delay in my reply.

I commend SUN's continued advocacy on behalf of Alberta's seniors, and I recognize your desire to ensure they have access to high-quality health care. Alberta expects a growing demand for assisted living and related care options for Albertans, and the Ministry of Assisted Living and Social Services (ALSS) will address this development. ALSS will continue to support the stability, security, and well-being of vulnerable individuals, including seniors.

For the 2025-26 fall COVID-19 immunization program, Alberta's government considered guidance from the [National Advisory Committee on Immunization \(NACI\)](#) that did not recommend universal vaccination for Covid this year, and included some high-risk populations in its eligibility criteria based on severe outcome risk. As we remain committed to protecting Albertans at the highest risk of severe complications from the virus, COVID-19 vaccines have been made available to Albertans in a two-phased immunization program through public health clinics:

- **Phase 1:** Albertans in the following groups can receive the vaccine free of charge:
 - Residents of continuing care homes and seniors supportive living accommodations;
 - Homebound home care clients;
 - Individuals six months and older with underlying medical conditions or compromised immune systems as recommended by the NACI;
 - Health care workers;
 - Individuals experiencing homelessness; and
 - Albertans aged 65 and older receiving the Alberta Seniors Benefit.
- **Phase 2:** All other Albertans six months and older may receive the vaccine while supplies last. An administrative fee of \$100 will apply; however, some private health insurance plans will cover the cost.

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Please note that over 87% of seniors qualify for a free covid vaccine.

Vaccine distribution and eligibility assessments are being centralized through public health clinics to foster a more effective management of inventory and resource allocation. Additionally, select pharmacists can provide immunizations at continuing care and assisted living facilities through existing arrangements.

Further, the influenza and RSV immunization programs remain unchanged from previous years. Albertans can still receive the influenza vaccine for free at pharmacies. More details about the fall immunization program are available at alberta.ca/COVID.

I also want to assure you that we are committed to ensuring essential medications remain affordable for Albertans through drug coverage programs, which pay for about 40 per cent of prescribed drug costs in the province. This is one of the highest rates in Canada and well above the national average of around 30 per cent. However, the cost to provide this coverage is rising significantly due to factors such as increasing drug prices, population growth, and an aging population. To maintain the long-term sustainability of these programs and keep medications accessible, an increase to the maximum co-payment for seniors was necessary.

As of July 1, 2025, the maximum co-payment is increasing \$1 each month from \$25 until it reaches \$35 in April 2026. The average prescription co-payment is \$11.30 for Albertans with Non-Group Coverage and \$8.44 for those with Coverage for Seniors. It is anticipated that these average co-payments will increase to \$14.31 and \$9.87, respectively. This phased, gradual approach provides predictability while minimizing the impact on Alberta families and seniors. While other options were considered, co-payments have not increased since 1994 and have not kept pace with inflation. If co-payments had increased in line with inflation since 1994, seniors would now be paying approximately \$48.

Most Albertans will still pay less than seniors in many other provinces. Currently, only about five per cent of seniors in the Coverage for Seniors program pay the maximum co-payment; however, the [Special Needs Assistance for Seniors](#) program offers financial support to help cover co-payments and other health-related costs. This approach balances fiscal responsibility with a commitment to keeping medications affordable for seniors across Alberta. We will monitor the impact of this change through a combination of data monitoring and financial analysis.

Thank you again for sharing your concerns and for SUN's dedication to ensuring Alberta's seniors are supported in all areas of health care.

Sincerely,



Adriana LaGrange
Minister of Primary and Preventative Health Services

cc: Honourable Jason Nixon, Minister of Assisted Living and Social Services